Article 370 in August 2019, through the Jammu and Kashmir Reorganisation Act, 2019, fulfilled a foundational demand that has animated the BJP and its predecessor from their very inception. This party objective is older even than the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, which the party formally embraced as a political goal only with the 1989 Palampur Resolution. The 'integration' of Kashmir, by contrast, was a fundamental party goal for the Jan Sangh right from 1951.

As early as February 1952, the Jan Sangh passed a political resolution emphasising the fact that India's constitutional provisions on Kashmir were 'of a temporary character'. The Sangh Central Working Committee's (CWC's) first resolution on internal affairs too asked for India to withdraw the issue from the UN.[78] It laid out expectations for the kind of state that Kashmir would eventually be when it 'integrates with India'. That same year, it declared that the State Constituent Assembly's decision to have a separate flag for Kashmir and its recommendations that the state be an autonomous republic within the Indian republic were a 'clear violation of India's sovereignty and the spirit of the Indian Constitution'.[79]

The BJP, in 2019, positioned the abrogation of Article 370 as the correction of a 'historical blunder'. 'In Jammu and Kashmir, Sardar Patel was right and Nehruji was wrong,' declared Union Law and Justice Minster Ravi Shankar Prasad in September 2019—again pitting 'secular' Nehru against 'Hindu traditionalist' Patel.[80] This may be an oversimplification of a complex historical story. Patel was, after all, the home minister of India at the time and Article 370 was passed with his consent. A fuller examination of Patel's role and how the Kashmir debate unfolded within the Congress at the time of accession is outside the scope of this book. But even if Patel was not the 'key architect' of Article 370, as the historian Srinath Raghavan has argued, the evidence does not indicate that he could have ensured full integration of Kashmir even if he had taken a more hands-on role.[81]

Between 1952 and 1972, the Jan Sangh passed as many as twenty-four political resolutions on Kashmir—almost one-third of all its resolutions on the wider issue of national unity. The revocation of Article 370 has also been a permanent fixture on BJP poll manifestos.